

Spinal cord

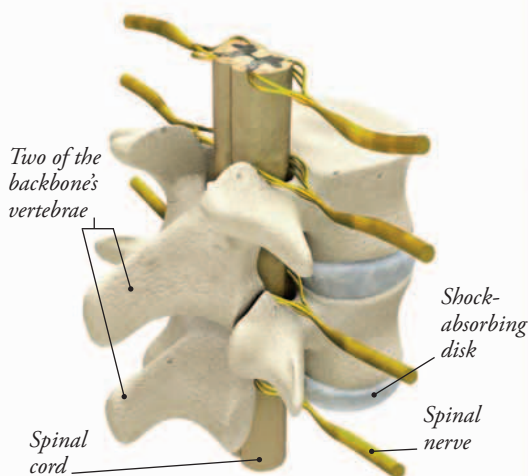
Stretching all the way down your back from your brain is your spinal cord—a large bundle of nerve tissues containing billions of nerve cells. The spinal cord carries information between the brain and most of the body. It also controls reflexes—automatic actions that happen without us having to think.

INFORMATION HIGHWAY

Your spinal cord is like a highway with smaller roads, in the form of spinal nerves, branching off it. Not all messages from the body travel to the brain. Some only get as far as the spinal cord, which activates a muscle or gland in response to a stimulus, such as making you pull your hand away from something hot. This is called a reflex action.

PROTECTION

The spinal cord is well protected. It runs through a tunnel formed by interlocking bones called vertebrae, which make up the spine. This protection is vital because damage to the spinal cord can have very serious effects. If the spinal cord gets broken by an injury, a person can become paralyzed (unable to move or feel their body).



Signals travel to and from the brain along the spinal cord.

The spinal cord extends 18 in (45 cm) down an adult's back.

Nerves branch out from the spinal cord in pairs.

WOW!

The spinal cord is no wider than a finger for most of its length yet it contains billions of nerve cell fibers.

Nerves from the base of the spinal cord run to the legs.